intention of his government was to curtail the rights of Indians/ a R&AW officer codenamed Prem Shekhawat told me.

A CIA report bolsters Shekhawat's observation. It said that sometime in 1982, Mara asserted that the opposition party dominated by ethnic Indians was being financed by the Soviets through the Indian embassy with the ultimate aim to oust his government. Mara had secretly appointed an internal probe which rubbished his views, but the findings of the investigation did not change his mind. Mara was quoted in an MEA cable as saying, 'Russia wants me out because it has been my influence that has successfully blocked Russian incursions into the Pacific. With me gone, they think they can gain a permanent foothold in the South Pacific.' His loyalty towards the Americans was evident from a declassified CIA report:

In 1982, overreacting in the Parliamentary election year to what he perceived to be the Fijian populace's anti-nuclear mood, Ratu Mara announced implementation of a previously unenforced ban on port calls by nuclear ships. The ban could have hindered movements of the US Pacific fleet, now over 40 per cent nuclear-powered. Mara later

became convinced of the safety of nuclear propulsion as a result of briefings at Honolulu, and in mid-1983, prevailed upon the Fijian cabinet to lift the ban. Since then, Fiji has not questioned whether visiting US Naval vessels are nuclear-armed. Mara's attitude is that such a query would be inappropriate in view of Fiji's dependence on US protection.

The R&AW chief and his team, recognising the depth of Indian roots in Fiji and India's larger interest in the region, went through several classified reports to understand the journey that had led to the coup. A fourteen-page secret note prepared